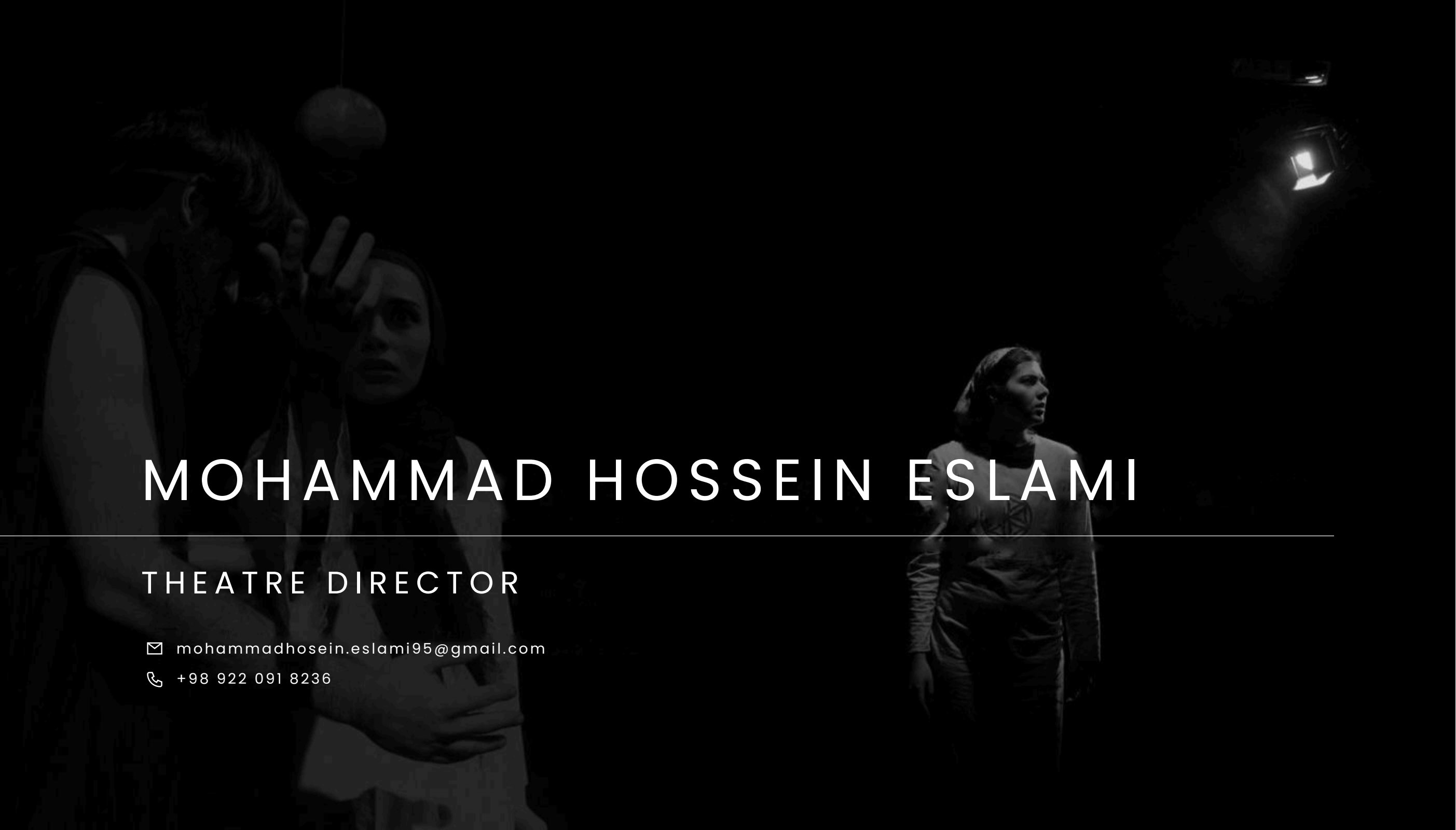




MOHAMMAD HOSSEIN ESLAMI

THEATRE DIRECTOR

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ABOUT

Mohammad Hossein Eslami

I am a theatre director based in Tehran. I hold an MA in Theatre Directing from Tehran University of Art, where my thesis studied the representation of identity in the work of Elizabeth LeCompte and my practical thesis was *Maid to Marry*. Before theatre I studied software engineering, and that background still shapes the way I bring media onto the stage.

My work moves between text-based theatre, devised ensemble work, live music, contemporary dance and media. I am drawn to postdramatic and political theatre and to intermediality, and I often design the scenography of my own productions.

I am currently directing, producing and designing the set for *Mephisto For Ever*, based on Tom Lanoye's play and Klaus Mann's novel, which opens in November 2026.

EDUCATION	MA Theatre Directing, Tehran University of Art (2019–2023) BSc Software Engineering, Shahid Beheshti University (2013–2018)
DIRECTING	Mephisto For Ever (2026) · Maid to Marry (2023) · King Lear (2021) · The Proposal (2020) · In Front of City Theater (2018) · Asgardia (2016)
DESIGN	Mixed Sandwich, media (2024) · The Good Person of Szechwan, set (2022)
PERFORMING	Saturday Nights (2017) · A Requiem for Oedipus (2015)

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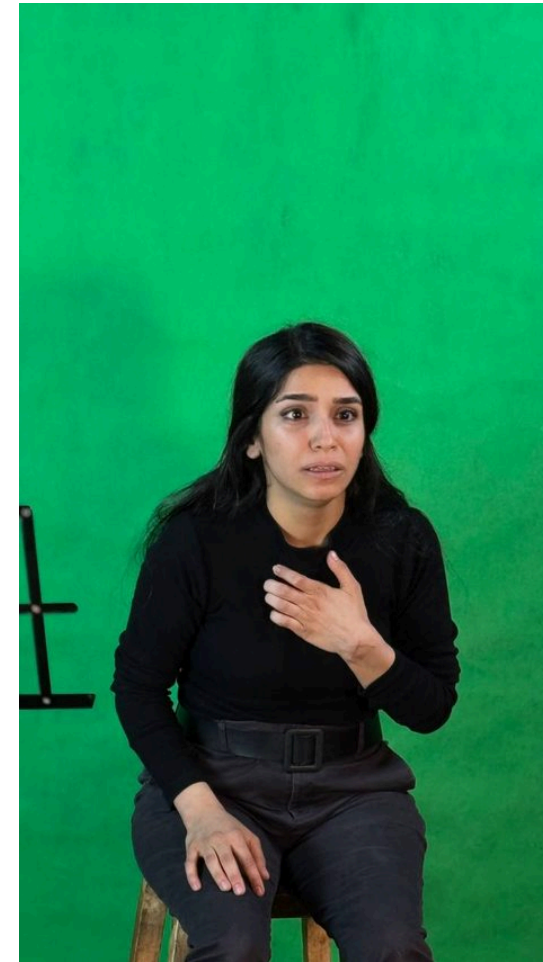
Mephisto For Ever

Director, Producer & Scene Designer

Based on Tom Lanoye's play and Klaus Mann's novel
Mephisto

— IN REHEARSAL · OPENING NOVEMBER 2026

Mephisto For Ever follows an actor who makes a deal with power so he can stay on stage. At its heart is a simple, uncomfortable question: what is left of art once beauty starts working for those in control? Our dramaturgical research moves between Goethe's *Faust*, its appropriation by Nazi cultural policy, and the life of Gustaf Gründgens. We want *Mephisto* to appear not as a devil who comes from outside, but as something already living inside the artist.

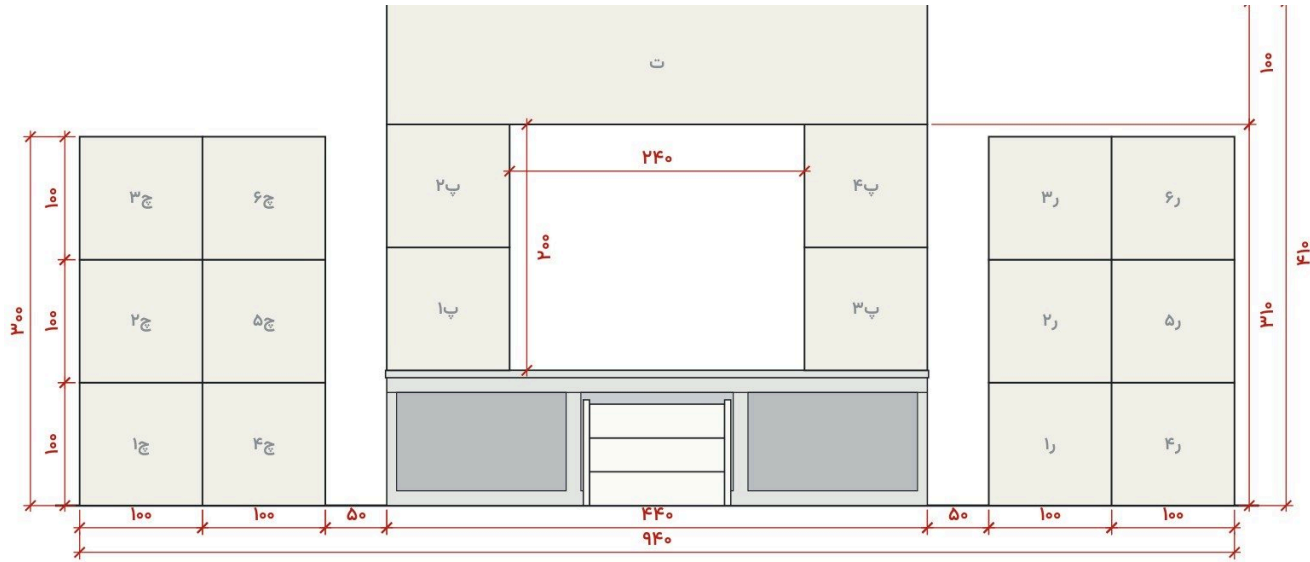


The production uses the carnival-like nature of a theatre company, framed as metatheatre: a troupe performing itself. Classical, modern, puppetry and contemporary dance sit side by side. Scenes of power are carried mostly by bodies, distance and image rather than words. The costumes decay across five stages, and their palette is designed together with the video mapping.

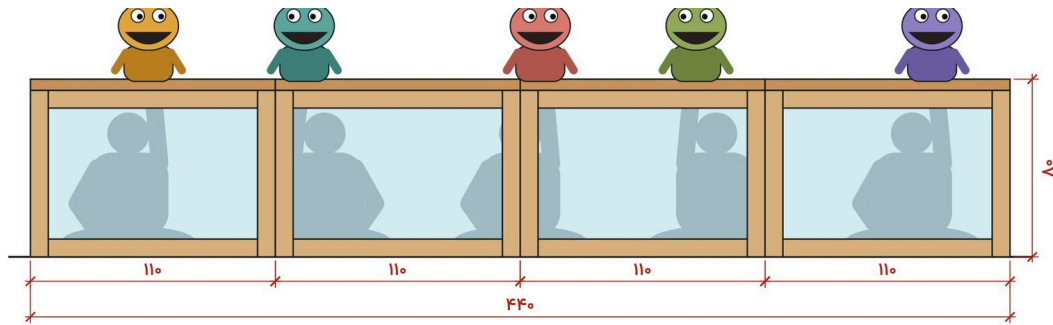
ROLE	Director, Producer & Scene Designer
TEXT	Tom Lanoye, <i>Mephisto For Ever</i>
NOVEL	Klaus Mann, <i>Mephisto</i>
STATUS	In rehearsal
OPENING	November 2026



What is left of art
once beauty starts working
for those in control?



SET: FRONT ELEVATION, SEEN FROM THE AUDIENCE



PUPPET STAGE: FOUR PLEXIGLASS FRAMES

SET	16 one-metre cubes · 4.4 m trussed arch · stepped platform · 9.4 × 4.1 m overall
PUPPETS	4 frames, 110 × 80 × 32 cm each, 4.4 m in all
MATERIALS	Pine, chicken wire, papier-mâché · timber, plexiglass, plywood



MEPHISTO FOR EVER · DESIGN

Set & Puppet Stage

I am also designing the set. One-metre cubes, a trussed arch and a stepped platform form a second, smaller stage inside the stage: an inner proscenium for a company that performs itself.

Puppetry is one of the languages the troupe uses to perform itself. The puppet stage is a row of four frames glazed with clear plexiglass, so the puppeteers stay visible behind their puppets.



3D PREVISUALISATION (PREVIS PRO): KURT AND NICOLE · KURT AND REBEKKA



Key sequences are blocked in 3D before they reach the rehearsal room, to test composition, light and the scale of the stage image.

In rehearsal we start from the body. Ribbon and movement work, shadow play and inverted bodies are tested as ways of carrying scenes of power through image and distance rather than words.



In Front of City Theater

DIRECTOR · CO-SCENE DESIGNER | 2018 | NEAUPHLE-LE-CHÂTEAU THEATER, TEHRAN

In Front of City Theater is based on a true story: the life of Sohrab A'raabi, who was killed during the Green Movement protests that followed Iran's 2009 presidential election. The play is built from four episodes, each told by someone close to Sohrab; together their accounts piece together what happened to him.

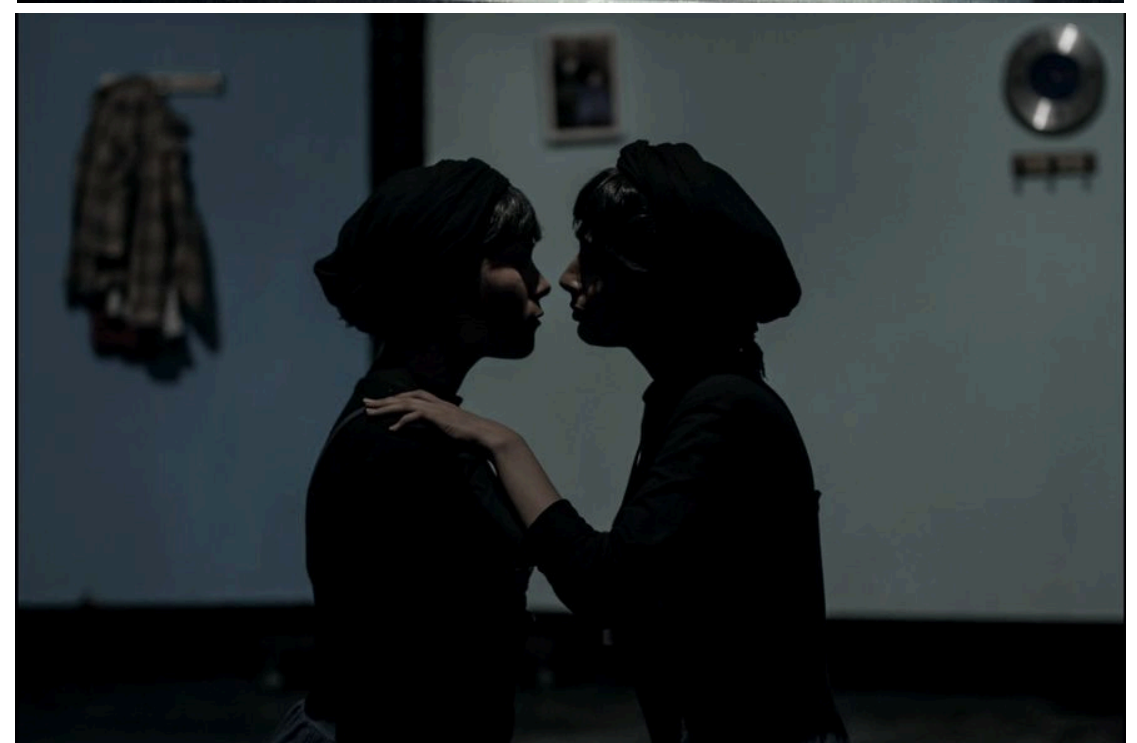
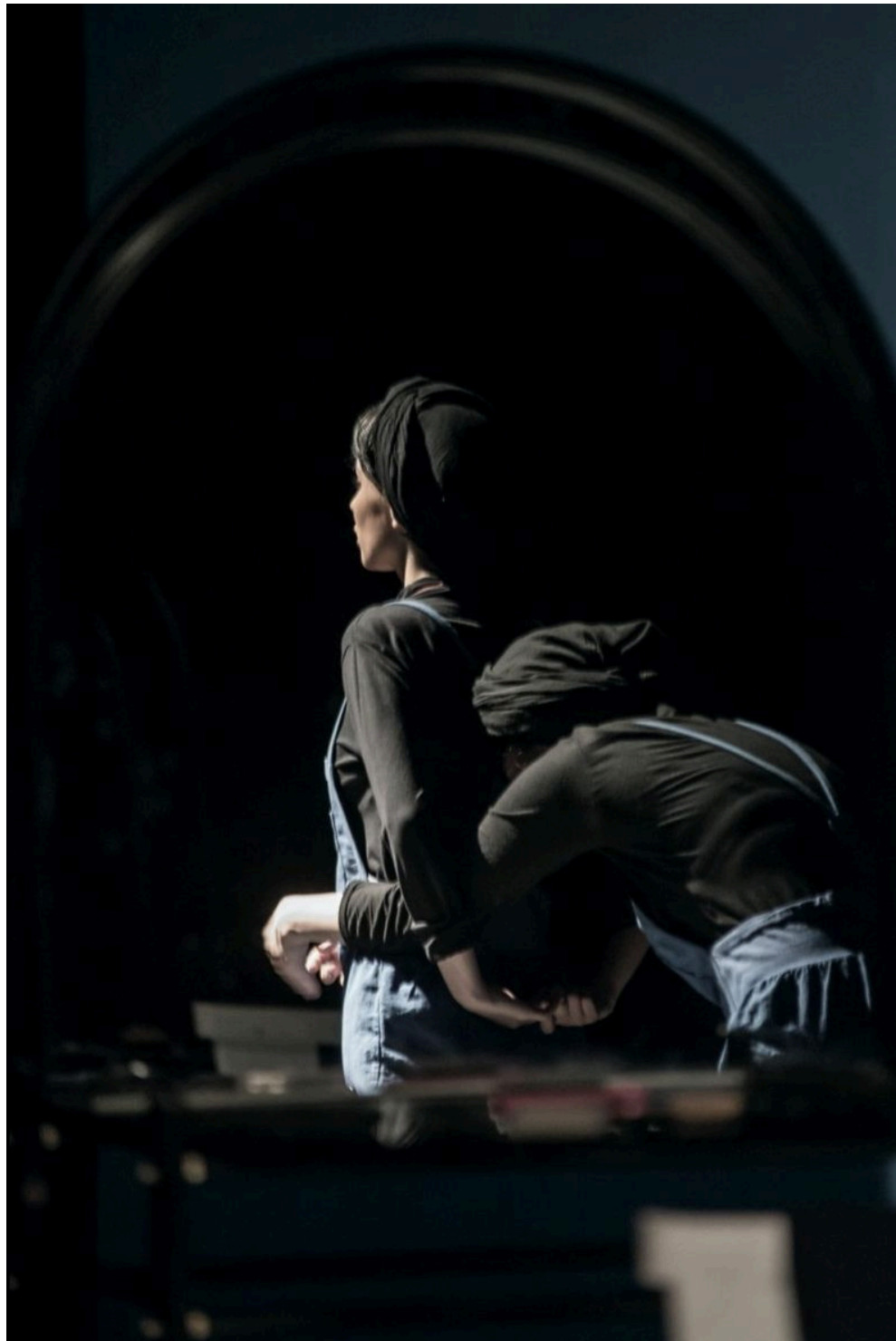
The text, by Salman Alighardashi, draws on classical Persian literature, and above all on the myth of Rostam and Sohrab in Ferdowsi's *Shahnameh*.



The production took a year to make, with a company of fifteen, six of them actors. One episode is built around choreography drawn from my training in contemporary dance: two actors play two sides of the same character, Zohreh, Sohrab's lover, and the scene borrows from Pina Bausch's trust exercises.



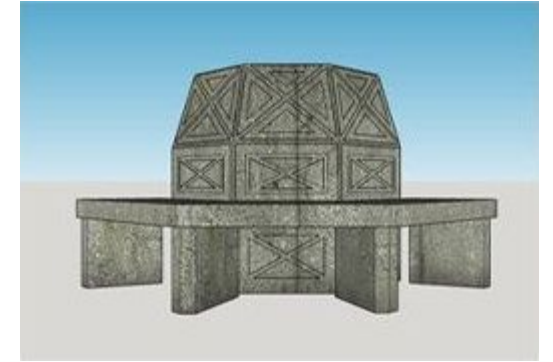
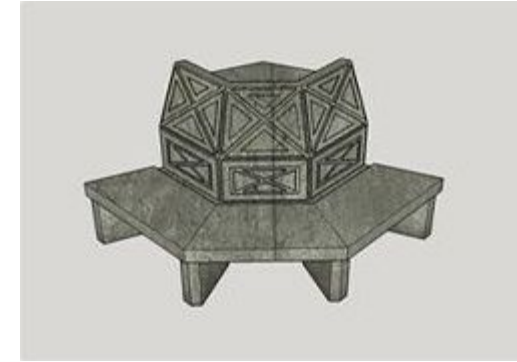
Photo : Mohammad Golmohammadi



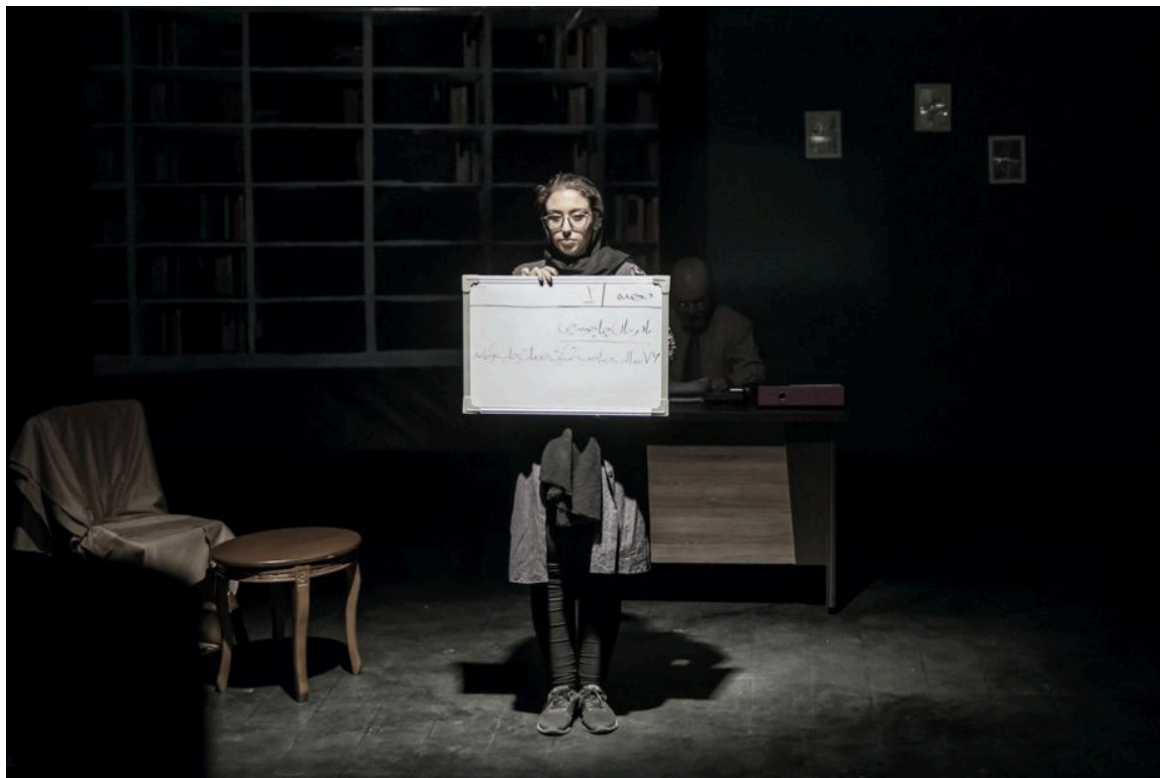


Live music runs through the performance. Five pieces were composed during rehearsals, mixing alternative rock with Persian folk music. The lyrics come from Mehdi Akhavan-Sales's poetry collection *The Ending of the Shahnameh*.

The music gives the story its emotional temperature and connects the episodes to one another.



I co-designed the set with Mohsen Khamechian. The starting point was the pop-up children's book: a metal structure that opens like pages, so that each scene unfolds out of it with its own objects, chapter by chapter of Sohrab's life. Designing and building it was the hardest technical problem of the production, and the one I learned most from.



Maid to Marry

DIRECTOR · MA PRACTICAL THESIS | 2023 | TEHRAN UNIVERSITY OF ART

Maid to Marry was my practical MA thesis in directing, supervised by Prof. Esmail Shafiee. It starts from Eugène Ionesco's short absurdist play about identity and adds a second subject: education.

The dramaturgy, developed with Mehdi Sharifi, uses other texts and a set of technical devices as mediators. Three performances run at the same time: a symbolic "cyber" version of the script on monitors; the play itself on stage; and seven teenagers, performers rather than actors, who play board games and describe their day as it happens.



The approach came from my theoretical thesis on Elizabeth LeCompte and The Wooster Group. As in her work, the source play is treated as raw material: we staged it while bringing in entirely different material, so that the text is heard through several voices at once.

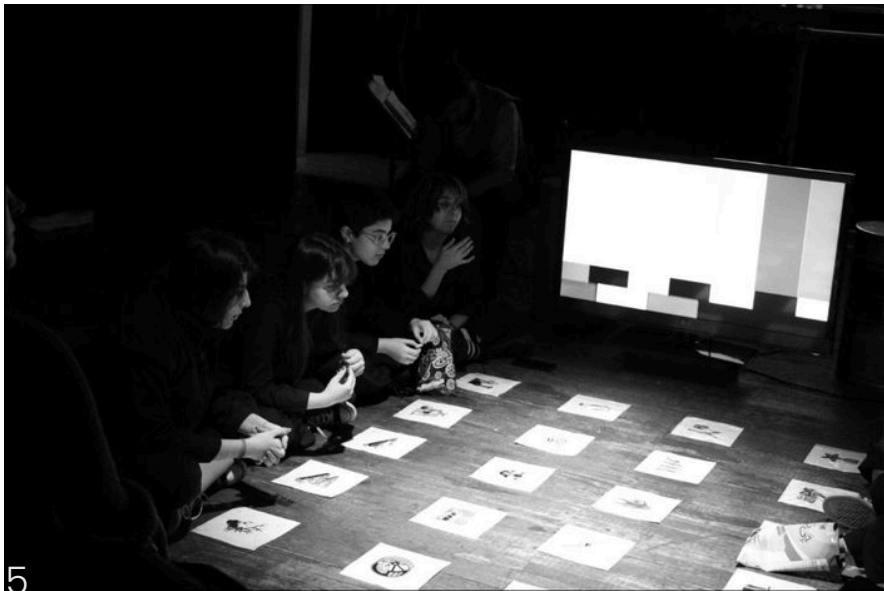
Everyone in the group proposed material, and anything that served the project went in. I saw my job as reshaping what came out of rehearsals rather than carrying out a plan decided in advance. It changed how I read a text, and it taught me to be sceptical of my own first ideas.







Much of the work was about the difference between an actor and a performer. The actors had to move between playing styles, and between dramatic and non-dramatic moments, which meant finding a shared vocabulary with them. The two main characters were each played by two actors, one live on stage and one through the screens, so every scene had to be timed between bodies and technology.





Asgardia

DIRECTOR · CO-PLAYWRIGHT | 2016 | MASHAYEKHI THEATER HALL,
TEHRAN

Asgardia, co-written with Reyhane Yazdani, takes its name from the proposed first nation in space. Six strangers from very different backgrounds are chosen by a corporation for a mission to Asgardia. Shut inside a spaceship, they collide over their own desires.

Alongside this runs a mythic line drawn from the story of Adam and Eve in the Old Testament, which looks for the roots of human conflict at the beginning of existence and shows it as a cycle.





Asgardia was my first professional production as a director. There was no company when it started: we built the group from scratch, and training was part of the process.



The actors brought material that we, as writers, used to structure the story. From the first workshop to the premiere, the process took fourteen months.



It was a low-budget production, and managing money was as much part of the job as directing. Most of the eleven actors were performing professionally for the first time, which made it a lesson in leading a large ensemble.

The structure is episodic, with two lines running in parallel. The spaceship scenes are played realistically; between them, scenes outside time and place use dance and choreography to produce a *Verfremdungseffekt*, a distancing effect.



The Proposal

DIRECTOR | 2020 | TEHRAN UNIVERSITY OF ART | ANTON CHEKHOV

Chekhov's one-act comedy *The Proposal* was my final project for the Principles of Directing course in my MA, under the supervision of Prof. Esmail Shafiee. The task was to stage the text exactly as written, with no cuts or additions, while finding our own tone and style in the staging.





We analysed the text closely with the actors and decided to bring in the physical vocabulary of commedia dell'arte. Researching commedia and fitting its gestures to a classical Russian text was new territory for me; the challenge was to use it without breaking Chekhov's play.



King Lear

DIRECTOR · 2021 · TEHRAN UNIVERSITY OF ART

King Lear was my final project for the Advanced Directing 2 course in my MA, led by Prof. Esmaeil Shafiee. The task was to choose and stage the play's key scenes, and we centred on the storm, where Lear rages against his daughters on the heath.

With very limited resources, we made eight versions of the scene, each testing a different directorial element: light, staging, mise-en-scène. The final performance combined the strongest ideas. It taught me to pay attention to the scenes that look minor, which often hold the key to reading a play.

Other Projects

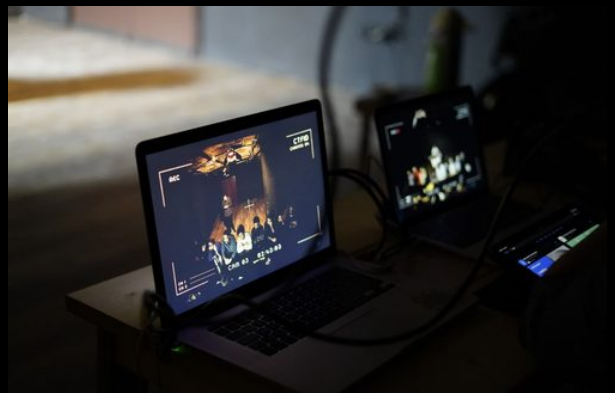
Actor · Scene Designer · Media



Mixed Sandwich

Media Producer & Media Projection Coordinator

An alternative underground production, staged independently without an official performance permit. Directed by Mohammad Hossein Heshmati and Aref Hassanzadeh, November 2024. I was responsible for producing the media content and coordinating the projection during the performance.



The Good Person of Szechwan

Scene Designer · Dir. Masoud Jahandideh · 2022



I designed the set for Bertolt Brecht's *The Good Person of Szechwan*, directed by Masoud Jahandideh at the Mehregan Theater in Tehran (2022).

My focus was the stage floor. I built a wooden floor that made specific sounds when the actors moved on it, so that the relationship between their bodies and the ground became a kind of music. Getting the notes right depended on exactly where the floor's frame was placed, and took a lot of testing.

Scene changes were fast and happened in front of the audience, so every object had to be light enough for the actors to carry without slowing them down. Joining a production that had been in rehearsal for months also showed me the work from the performers' side.





PAOIRPRANO



CHAPAR

چاپار

Saturday
Nights

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Fourth edition

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 (کیتار الکتریک) امیر حسن موسوی
 (کیتار الکتریک) حسین صیاد عبدی
 (پرفورمنس) فریوش آزور
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 آرمان برانی (کیتار الکتریک)
 هومن پیله وز (درامز)
 کیارش خرم (بسی سائز)
 حامد شاهی (بسی سائز)



تهران

Saturday Nights was a weekly series at the Independent Theater of Tehran that introduced new rock and metal bands. The band Padir wanted more than a concert, so they asked us to design and stage a full performance around their music. With Farnoosh Azor, I choreographed eight dance pieces and two short plays placed between the songs. Performing inside a concert showed me how closely music, movement and image depend on each other.

A Requiem for Oedipus was a student production at Shahid Beheshti University, made with the university's theatre association and philosophy society and directed by Abtin Gholampour. I was a member of the chorus. After researching the chorus in Sophocles, we reduced it to four performers. It was my first production at university, and an early lesson in persistence and teamwork.

A Requiem for Oedipus

Actor (Chorus) · 2015



علیرضا رضایی
هلیا امامی ال اقا
سینا امامی نیا
محسن خامه چیان
رضوان جهانبخش
محمد حسین اسلامی
مریم عبد اللهی
گلنار مقدم
تیرداد برقی
بیثا محمد حسینی
محمد خباز
راضیه سادات عقیلی
پریسا جهانپور
اشکان یار احمدی
ابتن غلامپور
فرنوش آزور
سعید چراغعلی
فاطمه نیایش نیا

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